

IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Wuxia (martial arts)

DIRECTOR

Ang Lee

WRITERS

Hui-Ling Wang, James Schamus, Tsai Kuo-Jung (screenplay); Wang Dulu (story)

STARS

Chow Yun-fat, Michelle Yeoh, Zhang Ziyi, Chang Chen

BEFORE

1991 *Once Upon a Time in China*, starring Jet Li, starts a craze for wuxia movies in Asia.**1993** Ang Lee's *The Wedding Banquet* is Oscar-nominated for Best Foreign Language film.

AFTER

2004 Zhang Yimou's visually stunning wuxia movie *House of Flying Daggers*, also starring Zhang Ziyi, is clearly aimed at Western audiences.

Movies including *Sense and Sensibility* (1995), *The Ice Storm* (1997), and *Ride With the Devil* (1999) propelled Ang Lee to the A-list of Hollywood directors. So it was a brave move to make his next project a martial arts movie set in ancient China with dialogue entirely in Mandarin Chinese. Yet *Crouching Tiger, Hidden Dragon* justified the risk.

The movie is based on a wuxia novel (see box, below), written in the 1930s by Chinese author Wang Dulu, the fourth title in his five-part *Crane-Iron Series*. In the US and in Europe, the movie was an instant critical and commercial hit, and won the Oscar for best foreign film.

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It's a good exam—
how to tell a story
with a global sense.

Ang Lee

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Critics noted the way it seemed to capture an idealized China, a China of dreams. As Ang Lee himself admitted, such a place never really existed. But the combination of romance, balletic martial arts sequences, and poetic cinematography created a movie that Western audiences engaged with. In China itself, however, the initial response to the movie was less positive, and an appreciation of its merits was slow in coming.

Among the best-known wuxia in the West are the *Once Upon a Time in China* series, which are regarded as some of the best of the genre. Many Chinese critics viewed Ang Lee, despite his Chinese roots, as a cultural tourist jumping on the wuxia bandwagon and getting it wrong. The martial arts sequences were tame, they complained. There was too much talk and not enough action. In their opinion, Ang Lee was pandering to Western audiences' need for emotional involvement.

Yet engaging the audiences emotionally and psychologically is precisely what Ang Lee intended. He believed that the popular martial arts movies had barely begun to explore the true meaning

Wuxia movies

Wuxia stories are an old tradition in China. The word *wuxia* means chivalrous warrior, and first emerged during the Ming Dynasty (1368–1644). Like the knights of European romances, *wuxia* combined a quest for personal perfection with skill in combat. Ming and Qing rulers tried to suppress *wuxia* stories because of their emphasis on social justice, but they remained hugely popular. The first *wuxia* movies were made in the 1920s, but it was in the

1960s that they became a phenomenon in China. In the 1990s, Hong Kong filmmakers made the *Once Upon a Time in China* series, featuring the folk hero Wong Fei-hung (played by Jet Li, left).

Crouching Tiger, Hidden Dragon changed the nature of *wuxia* in China, with movies such as Zhang Yimou's *House of Flying Daggers* (2004) telling a more psychological story than the earlier action-led movies.